Chaos and Control

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/54886564.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Swift Wind | Spirit, Catra & Swift Wind | Spirit, Adora & Perfuma (She-Ra), Catra & Perfuma (She-Ra), Adora & Angella (She-Ra), Angella & Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Angella (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), OC Wolf Characters

Additional Tags:
Self-Harm, Self-Hatred, Self-Esteem Issues, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Parental Angella (She-Ra), Implied Specism, Angella Isn't Perfect, Childhood Trauma, Mind Rape, Bright Moon Has A Slight Problem With Specism, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Adora has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (She-Ra), Adora Has Nightmares (She-Ra), Adora Has a Savior Complex (She-Ra), Adora Has ADHD (She-Ra), Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Catra has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (She-Ra), Catra is Emotionally Constipated, Trying To Help Your Friend When The Only Answer You've Ever Been Taught Is Violence, Perfuma is a good friend, Angst with a Hopeful Ending, Protective Catra (She-Ra), Protective Swift Wind, Wolf Swift Wind, Realizing That "Those" People Are Still People

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Part 3 of She-Ra Wolverine AU

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by Utter_Immolation

Summary

Adora can't sleep. This becomes everyone's problem.

Or

Some wounds linger, even on the girl with the healing factor.

Notes

(Takes place between this AUs S2 and S3)

Catra tells her she used to flail in her sleep.

Of course, Adora does not remember. Her memories are a ravaged, moth-eaten cloth. She doesn't remember her favorite food (gray bars) or her former squadmates names (Lonnie, Rogelio and Kurt) or even her age (nineteen, maybe, it's weird). Her sleeping habits are the least of her concern, and the past is quickly consumed by the demands of the future. What does how she sleep matters when there's a war ongoing?

Except it apparently does, because the first time she asked Catra why she was sleeping at the foot of the bed instead of in the middle of the cuddle pile (or on top, as she was wont to do) Catra had snarled at her and stormed out and refused to sleep with her for almost a week.

(“Stop saying it like that!”

“But…that's what we do?”)

And that would have been fine if that was it. But…it wasn't. It was her. She was the problem. As always. Well, partially.

Even when she was surrounded by her pack, the crimson lightning flooded her mind and she dreamed, horrible dreams of agony and anger and sweat and pain and hunger. She stalked screaming

figures through metal halls and buried her claws and teeth into their flesh, broke their bones and still wanted more, more, *more* , ***more*** —

When she wakes, she stiffens. Her teeth grit until they break. Her muscles tremble and shake and she forces them to be still, forces tension through them until they tear. Her fangs, elongated, slice into her cheeks, her lips, her tongue and she swallows and chokes on mouthfuls of her own blood and drool and flesh. She angles and twists her wrists and she tries to muffle the cracking and squelching as her claws struggle to break through her radius. Sometimes it works. Other times she watches, almost through a trance as parts of a claw break through her mangled wrists, tendrils of blood and fragments of bone wrapped the spiky appendage.

It's agony. Of course it is. But she'll break herself a thousand times before she loses control. She can't lose control. Can't lash out.

(In her dreams, she pulls her maw from Bow's torso and wipes the spurting blood from Glimmer's ravaged neck from her eyes. She steps over her pack's bloody pelts and stalks through Brightmoon's slick and bloody halls. She kicks aside the blood-stained helmets of the palace guard, bats aside the newly crimson feathers of an Angel's ruined wings and walks through the broken door of her quarters to loom over the magicat sprawled upon the rumpled sheets. The one that shows no fear and she ***hates*** and ***wants and HUNGERS—***)

(~~Catra beckons her, and sometimes the magicat carves her own chest open and lets her consume the heart within and other times~~

~~she presents her own and the woman lets her climb up and over her, lets her touch, lets her claw, all mine, mine~~ *mine* , ***mine***)

Those nights all she can do is carefully extricate herself from the pile and carefully and deliberately crawl to the ensuite bathroom, lock the door, turn on the shower and then rabidly tear into her own flesh. She curls beneath the icy spray and lets her fangs tear strips and chunks out of her arms, until they scrape against bone, until they crack and dislodge from her gums. She lets the hot blood pour out and mingle with the freezing water, until she's dizzy and lightheaded and her arms are as pristine as ever and the urge to tear the world to bloody shreds has abated.

It is in no way a *perfect* system, but it's an effective, and most importantly, hidden system.

She thought.

“A sleepover?” She echoes, looking from each eager face to another. Well, Mermista's face was as bored as always but it's a far enough cry from Adora's shocked own.

“Yep,” Catra replies, popping the ‘p’ and Adora narrows her eyes at the magicat accusingly. Catra *hated* sleepovers. Adora and the pack could sometimes tolerate them, but if they were territorial about their space, Catra was even more so. There was a reason that, if Glimmer insisted upon “team bonding”, that any sleepover they managed to drag Catra to took place in the heir’s room.

So for there to not only be a sleepover in their den, but one proposed by *Catra herself*…Adora knew she wasn't always the sharpest dagger in the armory but she could certainly smell a pile of fresh excrement.

But why? Could…could Catra *know* ? No, of course n—

“Unless you're having some trouble *sleeping*, Adora?” The feline hybrid cocked her hip, brow raised in that infuriatingly smug expression and tail flicking with satisfaction reserved for sleeping in sunspots, getting the last tuna sandwich and sending her foes running in terror. That's to say, cute in every situation except this one.

Because Adora didn't remember everything, but most of the translation guide to Catra-ism was instinctual and that was a surefire way of realizing: Catra knew. But for how long? And to what extent?

“Adora?” And Bow was looking at her with that expression of worry and concern now, Perfuma not far behind him, and she knew she had to nip this.

“Yeah, that's cool,” she managed, slouching back into her seat and trying her best to look unbothered and bored. “I'll tell the pups to make sure our toys are back in the box.”

Frosta raised her brow, almost managing to look imperious. “Our?”

“I like the squeaky toys, too.”

“She likes the squeaky toys, too.”

Adora glances questioningly at the second speaker, but is unsurprised to find its owner seemingly preoccupied with picking at her claws. Looking away, she sees how the other Princesses are gazing between her, Catra and themselves with knowing looks.

“Those aren't puppies anymore,” Mermista muttered, taking pity on her and moving the conversation along. “They're as big as donkeys.”

“I think they're adorable!” Perfuma gushed. “Even when they dig into the flower beds.”

“Also,” Bow pointed out, “technically speaking, given their current paw size to their overall bulk and their ages, they still *are* puppies.”

“Not my point. Isn't that room a bit small for all of us and the dogs?”

“No.”

“Yes.”

This time whe Adora looks over, Catra is meeting her gaze challengingly. For her part, Adora can only sputter indignantly. “It's cozy!”

“No, it's crowded and that's before you add five other people.”

“It was your suggestion!”

“Obviously, I didn't mean my room.”

“*Your* room?”

“What, kidnap victims don't get rooms nowadays? At least the Horde gives you your own cell.”

“Well,” Bow piped up, trying in vain to curtail the coming argument. “We can find another place! The castle is huge—”

Adora felt that familiar itching along her bones, in her teeth, as irritation flooded her veins. Drool gathered in her mouth and some leaked out as she snapped back, completely talking over the archer. “Are you going to bring that up, all the time?”

Catra smirked. “Is it working?”

Perfuma tentatively raised her hand. “Um. Maybe we should—”

Yes . “On getting on my last nerve, you mean?”

“Bit tense, aren't you Princess?”

“Guys, come on—” Bow tried again.

“You got something you wanna *say*, *kitten*?”

That smug smirk finally slips for a moment, only to come back with a sharper, more sardonic edge. “Aww. Does someone need a *nap*?”

When Adora opens her mouth to fire back, what comes out is a throaty snarl. Her mouth snaps shut. Blood rushes to her cheeks. The meeting room is silent.

Catra isn't saying or doing anything, no snarky comment or smarmy grin. She just gazes at Adora, silent, attentive and searching.

Adora can't meet her gaze. She moves to sit down—she hadn't even noticed herself standing—only for her arm to meet resistance. Her blood ran cold as she glanced to the side and saw her extended claws buried in the fine wooden table. Slowly, her gaze moved up and around, quailing under the Alliance's shocked and nervous—no, *fearful*—looks. Mermista's grip on her trident had tightened. The air around Frosta's fists had cooled, the table wet with condensation. Glimmer looked ready to teleport and only quickly moved out of her stance when Adora looked at her. Bow too had frozen under Adora's gaze, quickly pulling his outstretched hand away from his back and quiver. The only one not halfway ready to fight was Perfuma, though she still looked anxious and worried.

Slowly she retracted her claws, wincing at scraping noise they made as they carved their way back through wood and into their internal sheath.

“Sorry,” she says awkwardly. “Sleepover sounds great. I'll…I'll be there.”

The Alliance exchanged looks. “Adora—” Glimmer begins.

She doesn't wait to hear it. She hastily darts away, ducking her head as the guards tighten their grip upon their spears when she passes. She's already ripped a fang out before she's halfway down the hall.

“Hunt with me,” Faolin demands, twisting around from where he'd been rolling on the grass. “I'm hungry.”

Rama huffed. “You're always hungry.”

“I'm a growing pup!”

“Believe me, no you're not.”

Faolin growled and leapt at his larger sibling only to tumble through her intangible form with a startled yelp.

Laying off to the side near the garden's small pond, Akera rolled her eyes. “Idiot pup.” Her hind legs stretched out and shoved the lone human (ish) member back up the hill she'd been slowly rolling down and been pushed back up for the last half an hour.

Adora for her part didn't seem too bothered—if anything, being a makeshift toy seemed to smooth a fraction of the ever present turmoil and dismay that had creased her brow for the last week. Only a fraction, mind—the whole pack could feel her exhaustion, worry, fear and self-loathing, all curling around in her head and heart like a rancid and poisonous furball.

It made them all want to bite, to attack and defend. But there was no enemy to fight here. Nothing that could be barked and growled at to flee, nothing they could hunt down and destroy. It was infuriating, especially when Adora constantly smelled of blood and sweat and musky anger. No amount of cuddles or training or food seemed to be able to get her to open up.

Swift Wind seemed the most agitated of the all, constantly looking at the Boss with worry in his mismatched eyes. A braggart he may be, but Swift Wind took his self-proclaimed role as second in command quite seriously and his inability to help, Akera knew, was driving him crazy. Even now as he paddled about in the pond, he always kept an eye on their rolling leader.

For her part, Akera blamed the cat—her and the Witch. Things were always twisted when it came to them. Whatever their relationship had been in the Horde, it had certainly never been healthy. Most of the pack was disappointed that they'd never been able to sink their teeth into the woman who'd tortured and mindwiped their packmate, and it was only Adora's confusing and Catra's passive aggressive affection for each other that prevented them from driving the cat out

Well, that and Swift Wind. Despite his constant complaints, the Second had something of a clear affection for the former Horde Captain. Perhaps because as much as she and he sniped at each other, even Akera could begrudgingly admit that they had Adora's best interests at heart. A pity the cat was as emotionally stopped up as their room's shower drain.

Swift Wind pulled himself from the pond, shaking out his fur. “No hunting. Everyone bathe. We're making a good impression

tonight.”

“Speak for yourself,” Rama snorted, shaking her fur free of dirt and grass and sauntering towards the pond, taking a moment to gently nudge the limp Adora as she rested against Akera's flank. “I'm always delightful.”

“No you're not,” Faolin piped up, darting over with the eagerness of a child sensing the opportunity to one-up their sibling. “Remember the steak?”

Rama whipped about, intending to bap her brother on the head, but Akera casually kicked her leg, sending her off balance and giving Faolin the chance to bowl into her and knock her clear off her unstable footing with his superior strength. The two bounced and rolled down the slope, yelping and yelling insults until they hit the water with a heavy splash.

Adora gave a tired giggle at their antics, and Akera and the approaching Swift Wind's tails wagged at the sound. It was a welcome sound, a glorious difference to the muffled sobs and snarls they'd been hearing.

“Hey, Adora.”

The whole pack stiffened. Adora stopped laughing and seemed to fold in on herself. “Hey…Catra.”

“You don't sound happy to see me,” the magicat drawled, sashaying over to the pack and plopping herself onto Adora's stomach. Akera could practically hear Adora's heavy swallow. “Do you have to sit right there?” the pack boss complains, Catra's tail practically in her mouth, and her eyes…considerably lower.

Well.

Akera caught Swift Wind's eyes and the latter rolled his eyes so hard he nearly fell over.

“What? I'm not doing anything.” Catra wiggled her ass, grinding into Adora's sternum.

Adora's face went through a stream of emotions in quick succession: desire, confusion, *fear*. A split second later Catra yowled as she was forcibly levered up and off the blonde's chest. “Hey! The hell!?”

Adora stood, brushing her clothes. “Yes, you did! What are you planning?”

Catra rearranged herself on the grass, leaning against Akera like she was a living couch and picking at her claws, a surefire tell. The wolf thought about rolling on to her but decided to wait it

out, curious and wary about the upcoming conversation. “Want to be a bit more specific?”

The blonde's fist clench and Akera notes subtle movement under the skin. “The sleepover. You hate other people in our room. And it's *our* room, don't give me that “prisoner” line.”

Catra quirked a furry brow. “Maybe I'm embracing the Rebellion way. Besides, why do you care? Did you want some peace and quiet for your maiming?”

The air turns icy. Rama and Faolin pull themselves from the lake and creep closer

“What are y—”

“Don't lie to me, Adora!” The feline sprang to her feet. “I smell the blood. I hear the noises.”

Adora's jaw worked. “It's just nightmares. Nothing to worry about. It's fine.”

“Bull.”

“ *I'm fine*—”

“STOP LYING!”

In a flash of tawny fur and golden hair, the two were suddenly tussling about on the grass. Only this wasn't the playful fighting they were used to. All too quickly it became clear that Adora wasn't holding back. Her fangs were elongated, her grip was too tight, her claws were sliding out—

Akera slammed to her paws but as befitting his name Swift Wind was quicker and he darted forward, grabbing Adora's wrist in his teeth and yanking her back. Yet she didn't stop, not really, and Akera had to yank Catra back as a trio of claws nearly took off her jaw. Rama and Faolin slammed on top of the writhing blonde, lending their weight and strength to Swift Wind's and forcibly pushing the pack leader to the ground.

Catra twisted in Akera's grasp. “Let go!”

The wolf hurled the cat to the ground and jumped on top of her. “Stop it!”

Catra squirmed, pushing at Akera's bulk with sheathed claws. “You stop it! I need to—”

"*What* on Etheria is happening here?"

Everyone freezes as the regal Queen Angella touches down, opaque wings sweeping away the disturbed and upturned earth, a half dozen guards with their ridiculous cloaks and helmets rushing up behind their monarch.

The Angel of Brightmoon looms imperiously over their group, pale brow arched. “Well? Do any of you care to explain why you are tearing up my west garden?”

The pack all looks at each other. Catra has her neck strained, mismatched eyes only for Adora. In turn the pack leader has shrunk in on herself, seemingly trying to hide under the combined weight and bulk of three nearly grown wolves.

When nobody appears willing to answer, Angella huffed. “I understand that there has been a difficult adjustment period, but this is *not* the Horde. Any debates among you will be handled with *civility*.”

Rama gave a quiet snort and Akera felt like mimicking her. They were *wolves*—this is how the debate got handled among the pack: tussling and ear pulling until someone gave in.

“Yes, Ma'am,” Adora kept her eyes glued to the ground and it felt wrong to witness the Hero of the Battle of Brightmoon practically showing her belly to an overgrown bird. “May I be excused?”

Angella stared at her for a moment before giving a nod. The rest of the pack crawled off of her and Adora quickly darted away, falling onto all fours before she even turned the corner. Catra squirmed until Akera released her and made to take off after the blonde, only to pull up short as Angella intercepted her.

"And *you* ," and Akera isn't the only one to bristle at the tone the Queen takes. Catra could be a pain in the ass, but she was still *Pack*. "I have trusted you to aid Adora—"

"You mean keep her leashed," Catra sneers.

"I do not wish to take specific measures with her, but as her long-time friend even you cannot deny the danger she poses—"

The feline gives a scratchy, wicked laugh. It's a cruel and bitter sound, and Akera steps forward even as the guards around Angella tighten their grips on their spears. "Oh. Oh, man. Do you even hear yourself? Adora might not remember but I do. And I remember that the only difference between what you say and what Shadow Weaver touted all our lives is that you don't smell like cheap wine and ozone."

"YOU DA—"

"YES!" The faint smell of iron filled the afternoon air as Catra's claws sliced into her palms. "Why do you think kids who get raised in the Horde like us stay in the Horde?"

Angella said nothing and Catra didn't wait to hear it. “Because though the Horde sucks ass, you know you belong there. You know that if you've got too many claws or teeth or scales or fur you still get a bunk. I see their faces in the market, in the palace. It's not just being former Horde—people like me are feral to them. And Adora? The moment they see her claws they never come near her again. Fuck the Horde, but at least there, it's honest. At least there, there's not some self righteous Princesses lording over us and pretending they're better! At least there, Hordak doesn't pretend tO GIVE A SHIT ABOUT US!”

The air is still, the garden deathly quiet. The wolves are standing, and Faolin tugs on Catra's bloody hand and gently licks at it. A bit of the wild look in her mismatched orbs fade and she raises her chin in defiance. “Your *Highness*.”

Angeĺla doesn't look at the hybrid's retreating form, too busy staring into space, lost in thought. With a shrug, Akera pads away to search out Adora's scent, Rama and Faolin close behind. The both are subdued, their earlier innocent play seemingly a lifetime away now.

Behind her, she hears Swift Wind speak. “Your Majesty?”

“...Yes, Swift Wind?”

“Be honest? If Adora wasn't She-Ra, would you have let her in with us?”

Akera's ears strain as she pads away, but she never hears Angella answer.

“You're impossible, you know that?”

A couple of months ago, Catra would have snarled or hissed or clawed at the sight of a giant wolf pulling himself up into her tree.

See? She can grow as a person.

Swift Wind could only jump-haul up into the lower branches, but it was enough, and they were clustered and sturdy enough for him to spread across three of them comfortably. “Want to tell me what that was back there?”

Catra scowled, staring out over the lush Brightmoon fields and gently flowing river. “I was tired of having to look up.” It's not a lie, exactly. How come every magical user with a superiority complex had to *loom*? At least Glimmer had the decency to be a short gremlin.

Swift Wind hummed, but said nothing. A part of Catra hated when he did that. He was such a nonstop smartass ninety-five percent of the time that it constantly threw her off her game the few

times he shut up and waited. Still, she was a patient hunter—she could outlast him.

“Why have you been letting Adora hurt herself?”

Usually.

Perhaps it was because of how raw she still felt after the confrontation with Angella and the disastrous attempt to get Adora to open up.

Swift Wind sighed. “I've only really suspected so far. She cleans up good. Adora is shockingly thorough when she wants to be.”

Catra snorted. Understatement. Everyone always rolled their eyes at Adora's pedantic nature until it was the reason they succeeded in infiltration exercises. She might have the usual grace of a rampaging tank, but Adora had an eye for details and the terrifying ability to make something look accidental or natural or both. She might not be able to disappear into the trees but she could set up a crime scene in such a way that you didn't realize you were supposed to track her until she was miles away. “For such a people-pleaser she does tend to have a habit of doing the opposite of what you expect. Or want,” she complains, unable to mask the sliver of bitterness that slipped into her tone.

Swift Wind huffed. “Don't tell me this is about the rescue again.”

“Kidnapping, and no. It's just…it's…” Catra dragged her fingers through her mane with a frustrated growl. “You weren't there. When we were kids. You didn't have to see how Shadow Weaver tore her apart. She was a cruel bitch to all of us, but me and Adora…”

She trailed off again, and below her Swift Wind's tail wagged impatiently but he forced himself to stay quiet, a model wolf waiting in a hunt. And eventually his patience was rewarded.

“A part of me still hates her, you know? Adora? Shadow Weaver loved to trot her out, loved to rub in our faces how much better her chosen student was. She didn't have to feel the pain when Shadow Weaver got angry, she doesn't have the scars, didn't have to hoard as much food because there was the chance she wouldn't get to eat for a few days for some made up transgression.

“But…I also remember what Shadow Weaver would do to her. The gloves she'd have to wear until her fingers turned purple. The way her hair and skin would slough off because Weaver thought she was too hairy. The way she'd dig her cold, spindly fingers into Adora's mouth and pull her teeth out. The time she made her stand on a tiny little beam in the training room for an entire night because Weaver thought she slouched, never mind that sometimes she *needed* to run like I did.”

The hybrid sighed, leaning against the trunk of the tree. “Sometimes I hate Adora but then I realize I can't, not when I know Weaver's greatest crime against her.’

“What?”

“Hate. Weaver didn't need to hate her like she hated me, she only had to make her hate herself to keep her in check. I can be pissed all I want, but it's kind of a moot point when the only thing the person pissing me off dislikes is themself.

“And that makes me so fucking mad. At Weaver, at Adora, at... *me* . Because even after the bitch dies, even after a whole ass mind wipe, those lessons still live in Adora's head. The idiot is still letting Weaver control her, still letting her push me away like I can't handle it, like I'm still her fucking *responsibility*, still letting herself break to be a big damn hero, even when everyone else is treating her like *shit*—”

Catra broke off, her claws slicing into the bark, trying to control her breathing even as her tail lashed back and forth like a loose hose.

“She smiled, you know? Years ago. I don't know if she remembers but…they made us shoot her. Kill her. Treat her like a fucking test dummy, to get us blooded. Make us killers. They made us shoot her, and she just smiled after and said it was okay, that it was what she was made for. Squawked about sacrifice and the Glorious Horde and had the gall to ask me why I didn't do it. Why I didn't *murder* her, why I didn't do my fucking *duty*.”

A part of Catra loathes spilling her guts like this, but Swift Wind is about as neutral a sounding board as it gets, always insisting she's part of the pack in the same breath he used to insult her. And she needs to tell someone, because stars know she can't tell Adora, even if its to help her.

Especially if it's to help her.

“You should have been born a wolf,” Swift Wind grumbles after a long moment. “It's better. But then again, cats don't ever listen and maybe that's what Adora needs.”

He leaned on the branches and sighed, abruptly exhausted. “The Pack listens to the Boss. It's natural. But maybe sometimes we shouldn't. Maybe sometimes we need to be like…cats.”

The sheer distaste in his voice might have pissed her off coming from anyone else, but from Swift Wind it just made Catra laugh, the knot of anger and worry in her chest loosening ever so slightly. “Come on you overgrown mutt,” she jeered, leaping down from the tree and stretching. “We've got a party to attend.”

Swift Wind cautiously wiggled on his branches. “Are you going to help a packmate down?”

Catra taps her chin. “Let me think…”

She turns and walks away.

“Huh? Oy!”

“Still thinking!”

“Cat! Get back here! CATRA!!”

Adora doesn't hide. Of course not. She-Ra doesn't hide. If she chooses to stay in a random closet for a couple hours, that's her prerogative.

She manages to catch a few winks standing up between the mops and brooms. It takes the edge off, beats back the exhaustion that seems to have settled like a weight on her mind. It's such a strange feeling, to both feel as if your brain is leaking from your ears and yet feeling as physically spry as ever. Her body does not ache and hurt, but her head feels as though cotton wrapped glass is rolling over her gray matter.

She might have chosen to “forget” about the sleepover, but the palace staff still needed their tools and Adora subsequently spent a half an hour comforting and reassuring the elderly butler who opened the closet door and got the fright of their life.

After that she wandered the halls, trying to ignore the way some of the servants stared at her wide-eyed or the way others would fall silent as she passed before erupting in whispers when they thought she couldn't hear. Her exploits in the Fright Zone and performance during the Battle of Brightmoon had made her infamous on both sides of the war, it seemed.

She can't blame them. The notion of what she could do with her claws was scary. The way she could lose herself in the thrill of the hunt, the savagery of the fight—that was *terrifying*.

And that was just what she remembered, what was known. How many other times had she gone on a rampage? Sometimes she had dreams of bloody, too small hands and screaming. How many had she killed? Was her reputation started that fateful night in the Fright Zone or far before?

Catra didn't get it. She was graceful, controlled, a sword with a scabbard. Adora was brutish, rough and wild, a chainsaw with a cracked blade, as likely to hurt herself as she was others.

Adora had to be careful. Had to be in control.

She wanders about the palace and grounds, doing her best to avoid people and when the sky darkened, began to creep towards her room. Maybe she could hide in their closet and sleep there for the night, avoiding the sleepover entirely. Of course at this point, Catra and Glimmer at the very least would be looking for her by now. Which meant she had to avoid them and get to the room without a servant revealing her location.

Hmmm.

"Huff, huff!"

Adora silently cursed the castle architect of who knew how many centuries ago. Why were all the walls so damn *smooth*? She winced every time her claws sunk into the pale stone, hoping that the damage wasn't too severe. Maybe no one would notice?

There! Her window!

It took another quarter of an hour to quietly maneuver herself across the smooth tower sides. Thankfully the rounded window was open and she slipped through and flopped on the floor with a quiet groan of relief. The whole thing was a pain in her ass but if it meant avoided a polite interrogation from the entire Princess Alliance, she'd gladly climb a thousand—

She paused. Blinked. That…was not her ceiling. Or drapes.

She slowly turned her head.

A half dozen eyes stared back at her.

Adora's jaw worked. “Ah,” she finally managed.

Perfuma clapped her hands delightedly. “I knew you'd join us tonight!”

“Yep,” Adora smiled weakly. “I uh…promised?”

“I'll let Glimmer and Catra know,” Faolin yipped from where he and the other wolves were being petted and scratched by Frosta. “Want to come with me, your Highness?”

“Yes!” Frosta squeaked excitedly, for once looking and sounding her age. She clambered onto Faolin's back and the wolf carefully trotted out of the room.

A large glob of punch floated over to hover by her face.

“You look half dead,” Mermista commented, not looking up from her latest book, one of her bare feet nestled in Sea Hawk's lap as he lovingly massaged it. “What did you do, run all over the palace?”

Walk, but that was neither here nor there. “Something like that.” Cautiously, she puckered her lips and slurped at the punch bubble, giving a tired and pleased hum as the fruity liquid dribbled down her throat. It's red enough and yet off enough to briefly wash away the phantom taste of blood.

Heavy paws land on her chest and she chokes as Rama unashamedly leans her chest, lapping enthusiastically at the punch globe. Adora pushed her, only to be glomped on by Akera.

By the time Faolin returned with Glimmer and Catra, Frosta perched regally on his back, Swift Wind had joined into the tussle and now three wolves and one sort-of human were wrestling with each other and trying to lap and bite at the floating ball of liquid being floated tantalizingly back and forth in time with twitches of Mermista's hand. Sea Hawk and Perfuma were cheering and clapping along while Mermista pretended to lazily read her book, hiding her small smile behind its pages.

Unseen by anyone as she trailed behind the Heir of Brightmoon, Catra gazed at the relaxed and open features of Adora rolling about the floor with giant piles of floof and felt her heart squeeze.

And then she took a deep breath and strode over, plucking an especially sparkly and swirly straw from a nearby cup, gracefully skipped past the wrestling mass of fur and blonde, stuck the straw directly into the punch ball and began to drink. It took her drinking several lungfuls before the pack realized what she was doing and gave yelps of indignation. Adora herself lunged up and scooped her up and Catra wiggled in her arms half-heartedly. She was so close, hands so large, strong, warm—

And then she was being dropped and Adora was stepping away, panic barely hidden in her eyes.

The moment passes, Adora plasters a wry and cocky grin on her face and jumps back into the small fray, careful not to crush the newly joined Frosta and in spite of the perfectly temperate room, Catra is left cold.

Adora feels cold.

The night moons are high in the sky, the full intensity of their lights only held at bay by the gauzy curtains draped about the large, circular window. By their movement and positioning she can tell it's about two in the morning. She doesn't remember how she knows that.

Her lids ache with the pain of keeping them open but she doesn't dare close them. If they slide shut, they will heed the siren call of sleep, the intoxicating whisper that wants to lure her with sweet relief before drowning her in fear and terror as the nightmares rise from their mental caves and hallows.

She's so tired. She's so scared.

She's so weak.

Her lids flutter, once, twice and…

Glimmer wakes up to something wet.

It's a slow spreading warmth, and so at first she doesn't quite register it as any more than her blanket.

But then the smell of copper begins to waft into her nose and she nearly sneezes, fully awakening her to the feel of something wet and sticky and—

She conjures a ball of light, ignoring the groaning protests of her sleeping companions and looks around. It's two passes before she catches sight of Adora.

The girl has retreated to the corner near the window and her gray, plain pajamas are…

Glimmer screams.

Perfuma is an observant person.

People tend to forget, given that she's not surrounded by towering castle walls or fielding an army garbed in elaborate armor, that she is a Runestone Princess. Oh, they remember the "Runestone" part, of course—her plants are a force to be reckoned with on the battlefield. They're quieter, faster and stronger than anyone tends to think and the enemy is often entangled ~~and consumed~~ faster than most would believe.

But it's the 'Princess' part people forget about.

Perfuma knows the whispers and jokes. About how her land is more of a hippy commune than a legitimate nation. About how their heads are always in the clouds. About how weak, how naive, how silly the Plumerians are, like overgrown children wearing flowers.

Anyone else would get offended. Perfuma simply smiles.

What need there be of anger when she knows the truth?

Knows how Plumeria is the farming backbone of the Rebellion, how a Plumarian scout has the ability to disappear between one

bit of foliage and the next with little more than a whisper and leaves. Knows how even though her people don't always know how to hold a spear, they do know how to dig a concealed pit of stakes. They know how to drizzle a concoction of belladonna and darkyew on tightly packed thorn bushes that Horde patrols are scheduled to squeeze through and knows more than half will be dead by morning.

(Here's a secret: deep beneath the ancient roots Plumarian oaks and cedar trees, beneath rolling hills their children frolic upon with glee, beneath legions of burbling creeks and rivers, there lay deposits of iron and minerals in such quantities as to make the mountains of Dryl weep in envy. Whether they be man or satyr or fairy, whether they wield sword or axe or spear, all return to the ground from whence they came.)

But beyond all of this, Perfuma is a Princess. A leader. The eldest. And while she knows that a word can be just as effective as a weapon, sometimes you have to *get* to that point first.

So when Glimmer screams in panic, and the guards storm in, Bow yelps, Mermista and Sea Hawk pop up in tandem, Frosta conjures ice fists, Catra yowls, the Pack howls, and Adora wakes from her half-awake self-mutilation, pales and tries to hurl herself out the window, Perfuma sighs and *acts*.

Vines snap out, wrapping about Adora mid-flight and slamming her back to earth. More vines lash out, pressing the guards against the walls and plucking their spears from their hands. She's as careful with her power as she is with her craft—the plants are as strong as sea cables, but they move with the victim, ensuring neither are hurt save the most extreme cases.

And then, in the midst of chaos, she taps Sea Hawk and leans in close. “Sea Hawk, an attention grabber please?”

The former pirate looks tired and confused but he gives a quick nod nonetheless, places a few fingers in his mouth and gives a piercing whistle that has Catra and the Pack whining and everyone else wincing.

Perfuma claps decisively in the silence. “Attention please! Everyone save Catra, please leave the room.”

One of the guards gives a half-hearted protest. “Ma'am, what about…?” Their helmet doesn't move, but Perfuma knows he's glancing at the trussed and wiggling Adora.

Perfuma doesn't react to his lack of acknowledgement of her title. It's nothing new. “There is no danger here.”

“But…ma'am…”

Perfuma smiles. The vines tighten.

The guards leave. With a bit of conjoling, everyone else piles out as well, Mermista and Sea Hawk very firmly blocking Frosta’s line

of sight even as she craned her neck trying to see the large bloodstain in the corner carpet.

The Pack stayed. “We’re not going anywhere,” Rama said quietly. Swift Wind had already crawled over to the bound Adora and was nosing her. Catra stood uneasily over them both, her tail lashing and her chest unconsciously leaning forward, as if her heart was trying to join the duo on the floor.

Perfuma tilted her head with a hum, before nodding her acquiescence.

With the mass of bodies gone, the space felt too big and empty. Perfuma waved a vine through the hovering ball of pink sparkles that remained until it dissipated, and tugged her pillow under her knee as she knelt before Adora. “Shhh. You will be released soon enough. But we need to speak first.” She waves invitingly at the still standing Catra, even as the rest of the Pack pressed in close. Eventually, hesitant and wary, the hybrid sat.

“Adora,” Perfuma began. “You're hurting.”

The blonde flicked an eye towards her, the blue orb gleaming in the dark. “It'll heal. It always does.”

She hummed. “The scars can be just as painful.”

“I don't scar.”

“Not here.” The Flower Princess tapped her shoulder. “Here.” The finger moved from her shoulder to her skull.

Adora froze, before straining to turn more fully towards her. “I'm not crazy,” she gritted out.

“Of course not,” Perfuma readily agreed. “I'd never say you are—in fact, I'd argue the term in itself is offensive and unhelpful. Very, very few people are ‘crazy’. They simply need different types of help. Types of healing.”

“So Adora's not crazy," Catra cut in. “So what's wrong with her?”

“Nothing!” Protested the girl on the floor.

“Bullshit!”

Perfuma gently cleared her throat. “Ladies.”

They reluctantly settled, still glowering at each other. “I'm not sick,” Adora insisted. “I heal from everything.” Her tone took on a bitter curl.

Perfuma leaned back. “Have either of you heard of ‘propagation’?” Faced with their sullen silence and the wolves silent attention, she continued. It's the act of cutting a piece of a plant away and replanting it, in order for it to grow into a duplicate. But even if it grows, there is still evidence of damage, if you know where to look. Even though it has healed, the trauma doesn't really go away. Not fully.”

She loosened the vines with a wave of her hand, reaching out to clasp Adora's as she warily sat up. “Your mind, be it from injury, magic or both, may have healed and continued to function, but such trauma doesn't simply…dissipate from your psyche. I know you've been having memory issues, but have you ever had a major injury and had it still ache the next day?”

Adora hesitated. “I remember…” she started reluctantly. “Pain in my chest and head. I remember it lingering for days. I…I don't remember why.”

“You got shot,” Catra said woodenly. Her tail had wrapped itself around her knees, her claws digging into the plush carpet. “In the Horde. Over and over and over.” She gave a broken chuckle. “You were a test dummy. They called it training, what they let the cadets do to you. They called it growing up.”

Perfuma doesn't let the nausea churning in her heart show on her face, nor does she give in to her urge to comfort Catra. Right now Adora is her focus and affection and Catra is something that is a heavy work in progress. “You may heal from lasers and knives but

the body is not static. Things linger, and it's no different with the mind."

Adora blinked. "I'm lashing out because my mind didn't heal all the way?"

"Something like that. But perhaps that's not the only reason. Words are weapons too. Arguably the worst kind—you can mend a broken bone or treat a burn. But words…they worm into you. They burrow into your heart and mind and haunt you. It's not so easy to heal words. Nor see the injury they cause until it's too late."

Adora doesn't speak for a long time. "I remember," she murmurs haltingly. "I remember her…she used to shave me…shock me…I couldn't be an animal, she'd say. I was going to be a Force Captain and Captains weren't beasts." One of her hands pulled loose of Perfuma's drifting towards her mouth.

Catra hissed and abruptly scooted forward, grabbing the straying arm and pulling it down. "Stop that." Her tail plopped into the loose grip, and Adora immediately began to stroke the furry appendage.

Perfuma let her distract herself for a moment. "You're not a beast or an animal, Adora. You are you, and what comes natural should not be constrained. It is not…subhuman to give into some of your instincts. They are what makes you, you, and they are nothing worth being ashamed about, let alone suppressing. Is Catra a

lesser being for licking herself clean rather than using the shower?”

Adora frowned, a familiar, protective glimmer emerging through her melancholy shell. “Of course not! It's just what she does. Even when she coughs hairballs into the sheets and leaves them.”

“Okay, that was *one time*—”

“Too many,” Swift Wind muttered.

Perfuma cut in before they could really get going. “If Catra's mannerisms are natural, how are yours *unnatural*?”

“But…” Adora looked at them all helplessly. “But people are afraid of me. Why else would they be afraid of me if I'm…?”

Catra snorted. “They're idiots, that's why.”

Perfuma huffed in wry amusement. In her personal opinion, Catra wasn't wrong but it wouldn't be conductive to say so. “Fear is rarely logical and unfortunately, neither are people. You can't control how people react to you, Adora, only how you react to others. Although,” she acknowledged, “the behaviors of those who judge you without warrant is rather—”

“Shameful.”

The group startled, turning to face the door that had quietly opened to admit the looming and faintly luminous form of Angella. She glided forward, graceful even in nothing more than a long silk shift, only faltering briefly at the darkening patch of blood in the corner before she shook herself and to the astonishment of almost everyone there, folded herself in to lower herself to her knees, wings tucked behind her.

“It is shameful,” she repeated. “How the people of Brightmoon have treated you. How *I* have treated you.”

“Your majesty—”

A firm hand forstalls Adora's protests. “I have been blind. I have allowed discrimination and prejudice to fester in my heart, my home and my kingdom. Brightmoon should be a place of equality and openness, acceptance and forgiveness. The Horde has caused pain, but it is no excuse to harden ourselves to the suffering of others. My husband—my husband never stopped fighting for the forgotten and downtrodden. And I have been so busy mourning him that I have failed to see his dream fulfilled—not only the defeat of the Horde but the rescue of those the Horde has tormented…both outside and within its walls.”

Adora opened her mouth but nothing came out, looking beseechingly at Catra. For her part, Catra for all of her passion said nothing, gazing steadily at the Queen with narrowed eyes.

“And so I find myself at a loss. We are at a crossroads in all things: the war, our beliefs. She-Ra has returned and as the tide shifts, we— *I* can no longer stand idly and pretend the waves do not wet my robes. I must dive. And I…I wish for your aid. Help me, help you and others like you. No…help me help other *Etherians*. Other children, who haven't a choice…and even the ones who did.”

“And you'll listen?” Catra said lowly. “You'll pay attention when there is a problem? When sh—we're hurting and everyone ignores it?”

Adora was still gazing awestruck at Angella but Perfuma could see the way her mismatched eyes flitted to Adora and back.

“You have my word.”

“You have to know that doesn't mean much to me,” Catra shot back.

“Catra!” Adora hissed but was ignored and then distracted, hissing as Faolin nosed her still weeping abdomen.

Angella gave a sad smile. “I know. But for right now, it is all I can give you.”

Catra scoffed and looked away. But tellingly, she didn't rebuke the immortal Queen.

“Adora.”

The blonde in question jumped. “Yes, your Majesty.”

“I would like you to do me a favor. A couple actually, though the first is more of a request.” She leaned forward and clasped Adora's hands, covering Perfuma and Catra's. The two former Horde soldiers looked down at the sight as if it were a pastel snake. “I should have asked you to do this before, to be fair, but… would you consent to speaking to a Mystacorian Mindhealer?”

Adora chewed the inside of her mouth. “Like a magical shrink?”

Angella tilted her head. “Yes and no. They do treat the rare cases like yours, where someone has been a victim of mental assault, but they also treat the more mundane, but no less important cases. Sometimes they prescribe potions, sometimes they give talismans, but often they simply…speak to you. And having lived for quite a while and seen quite a number of horrors…sometimes simply speaking can do wonders.”

Adora was silent and Angella continued. “And this applies to you as well Catra. I won't make it a favor, but I will ask that you consider it. I will be bringing it up with Glimmer and Bow as well. Princess Perfuma, I trust you have your own arrangements?”

“Of course.”

“Princesses Mermista and Frosta may be difficult. And we will need to set up a program for defectors…” Angella mused before shaking herself. “Secondly—I am aware She-Ra is powerful, and you yourself have incredible martial prowess and regeneration. But. Adora—armor. You will wear it.”

The Princess of Power stirred. “But—!”

“No. It is a source of distress for all to see you get hurt, even if you, as you say, can “take it”. If you insist on being at the forefront, you will be suitably attired. *That* is an order.”

Adora gave a small grumbling growl that turned into an adorable yelp as Catra's tail smacked her in the face.

“I have but one final question.” She squeezed the hand that held both Catra and Adora's. “Are you…happy here? In the palace? In these rooms?”

“They're very generous—” Adora hastened to say.

“No,” Catra interjected.

Adora glared. “We've been given more than enough—”

Angella gazed sadly at her. “That's not what I asked.”

Adora clamped her mouth shut.

“It's too pink,” Catra said boldly. “Too pink and cramped and not close enough to the Woods.”

“Then I will see what I can do. Adora?”

For several moments Adora didn't speak.

“Boss,” Swift Wind softly murmured.

Finally: “...yes.”

Perfuma squeezed her hand. A small, flowery vine grew between their clasped digits and bloomed a beautiful white. “And the Mindhealer? Catra?”

Catra's claws flexed and her tail lashed but eventually, she gave a terse nod.

“Adora? Will you try? Will you let us help?”

The blonde trembled, fingers flexing. Perfuma saw the faint movement under her skin of her claws moving back and forth, nearly being unsheathed only to be withdrawn. And eventually…

“...yes.”

“You could have told me you were worried.”

“I wasn't worried. And even if I was, would you have listened?”

“...probably not.”

“Exactly,” Catra stretched out on their new bed, a comfy, yet firmer monstrosity that had been pushed as close to their new double door balcony as possible. The last bedroom had been plenty big in her opinion, but could admit, privately, it had begun to be too small for her, Catra and four near-horse sized wolves. This room was the size of a small apartment, with a massive

balcony that opened up to easy access to the woods. More than likely, given their proximity to Glimmer's own suite, this had been meant for visiting dignitaries. And Adora could admit that something about the openness of the space and the plentiful fresh air, despite the security risk helped soothe somthing in her.

Or maybe it was the herb.

"Put that out," Catra grumbled. 'That' in question was a slim cigar packed with a relaxant herb blend provided by Perfuma. Her first Mindhealer appointment wasn't for another week, but Perfuma had let her experiment with a very mild dose, meant to relax her muscles, sooth her pain and slow her racing thoughts. She'd given Catra a similar herb bundle, though it had been placed in one of her toys—"Hunting practice tools!"—instead.

Unlike Adora's, it had made Catra sleepy and slothful, closer to a pile of liquid fur than a tightly coiled predator. The experience and loss of self-control, Adora thought, had freaked Catra out because she hadn't used it since. But, also, she hadn't discarded it either.

Adora had initially had her blend in one of her squeaky toys, but Catra had threatened to shred it if she kept squeaking it in their temporary new quarters, so Perfuma had offered the cigar instead. The feline hybrid had complained about that as well, but Adora pointed out it was either her smoking by the window or her squeaking about the room.

Catra chose the window with a not-so-graceful grumble.

“I'm celebrating your promotion.”

“Bullshit,” Catra snorted. But Adora heard the pleased curl in her voice.

Angella, having taken steps to have more “voices” in the Rebellion proceedings, had promoted Catra to ‘Co-Commander’, putting her on par with Glimmer, who hadn't looked too pleased with having to share her authority but didn't complain. In turn Adora had been given the rank of ‘Captain’, with the Pack as her Lieutenants. Swift Wind and Akera especially had been pleased as punch at their new adorable—”Sophisticated!”—collar rank stripes.

The Rebellion was changing. It was slow, of course—but yesterday, one of the guards had hesitantly asked to spar with her and one of the servants had looked at her with cautious curiosity rather than naked wariness and that…that Adora could deal with. Things were changing. A number of former Horde defects hidden in Brightmoon have cautiously approached the palace, asking for audiences. Asking to fight.

Yes. The Rebellion was changing. Growing. And Adora felt something that was almost like…hope.

(When had she stopped?)

Rama leaned against their elbow. “Come to bed, Boss. We've got the armor fittings tomorrow.”

“Right.” Adora glanced out the window one last time, her keen eyes catching sight of the tentative spot just through the woods that had been marked as a building spot for a small house. *Their* house, one day.

She extinguished her cigar, wincing slightly at the small mark it made on the banister, tried to discreetly wipe it away, gave up, shucked all but her small clothes and crawled in amongst her pack, huffing as Catra immediately plopped herself down across her stomach.

For the first time in weeks, she did not dream.

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